> uniforms. The condition of the men in such circumstances was pitiable, and every minute their sufferings increased. The water in the men's pots was soon exhausted. At midnight they began to flag, then to murmur, and shortly there was a universal cry of 'water – water!' Many were half-raving . . . One sepoy was in such a state that, when I spoke to him, he could scarcely reply; his tongue rattled in his mouth, and his whole countenance was distorted in agony.

It was not just the sepoys who were suffering:

> The poor, heavily laden camp-followers, some carrying infants, were in a more pitiable state still, and the children's cries were heartrending. Strong men, exhausted from carrying loads, were scattered on the ground moaning and beating their breasts . . . One of the native officers in camp had with him a little girl, his only child, whose mother was dead. She was a pretty, lively, prattling thing of about six years of age, the delight of everybody. I used to see her every day chattering to her father, helping him light the fire, and cook their food; and her pretty little ways were a delight to witness. I saw her at ten o'clock all well, and at 3pm she was dead and laid out for burial . . . [When they reached the camp at dawn] out of thirty-two wells dug in the bottom of a ravine, only six contained water. One of them was poisoned by an animal which had fallen into it, and of the others the water was so bitter and brackish that the men said it turned their lotas [brass pots] black.[29]

Then there was the gathering crescendo of attacks by Baluchi brigands. Inadequate diplomacy, high-handedness and a lack of co-ordination with local chieftains meant that the tribes of the area looked on the vulnerable British columns as fair game. The troops were generally left well alone, but the unprotected camp followers began to be robbed and murdered on a daily basis.

Neville Chamberlain was a young cavalry officer on his first campaign, and it was a week after leaving Shikarpur, near a waterhole, that he saw his first casualty: 'One woman lay – poor creature! – on the edge of the water, with her long black hair floating in the ripples of the clear stream.' Her throat had been cut from ear to ear. Many other casualties followed. 'The unburied dead were left rotting on the road. Not a tree or a shrub or a blade of grass could be seen through the light the moon afforded us. It was all sand, not a bird exists on this plane, not even a jackal – for we frequently passed camels in a putrid state and if there had been jackals they would be sure to have found them out. Our camels had nothing to eat for several days and forty-five died in one night from hunger and the length of the marches.'[30]

It was on these hot moonlit night marches that the troops caught what was for many of them their first glimpse of the man for whom they were risking their lives. 'Shah Shuja is an old man, about sixty years of age,' wrote